

Ethics

The action of viewing my classmate's information may not seem harmful if I don't do anything with the information, and don't tell them that I looked at it. This is referred to then as a harmless wrong. I argue that this is still harmful as the action of accessing someone's personal information is still a violation of privacy that my classmate has a right to. Accidentally looking at their personal files is a wrong to their privacy rights and can even cause reputational harm towards myself if they ever find out that I had looked at their files.

This also comes to my next point, that is the severity of the information that we are looking at. Information like account login info, or school assignments is a much greater violation of privacy than something like knowing what games they play in their Steam account. This relates to Citrine and Solove (2021)'s typology of privacy harms, where certain information being accessed poses more harm than others in terms of physical, reputational, economic, etc. harms.

In conclusion, Parfit's observation of privacy being more objective than subjective agrees with my argument that even while accessing my classmate's files, and not doing anything to them, is still a wrong to my classmate's privacy. As well, the type of information that I have accessed has differing severity to the harm posed. The action that I take after viewing also contributes to the severity of the harm that I cause to my classmate, that is if I go and publicly share this information to more people, like other classmates being able to directly access their files or indirectly messaging them of the information I saw, it can cause reputational harm. This ethical issue is complicated and has many nuances, but the overall action, even while not acting on knowing anything about the files we have just seen, is wrong and violates basic privacy rights.